

MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



Week 4: Understanding Research Philosophies and Approaches

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Strathmore Business School | MBA Evening 2026, Trimester II

By the End of This Session, You Will Be Able To...

1

Compare

positivism,
interpretivism,
pragmatism and realism
as research philosophies

2

Justify

a research philosophy
appropriate to a given
business topic

3

Distinguish

deductive, inductive and
abductive research
approaches, and match
each to a type of study

Reading: Saunders, Lewis & Thornhill (9th ed.), Chapter 4, pp. 128–175 — read before this session.

Activity: Philosophy diagnostic exercise, applied to each candidate's emerging topic.

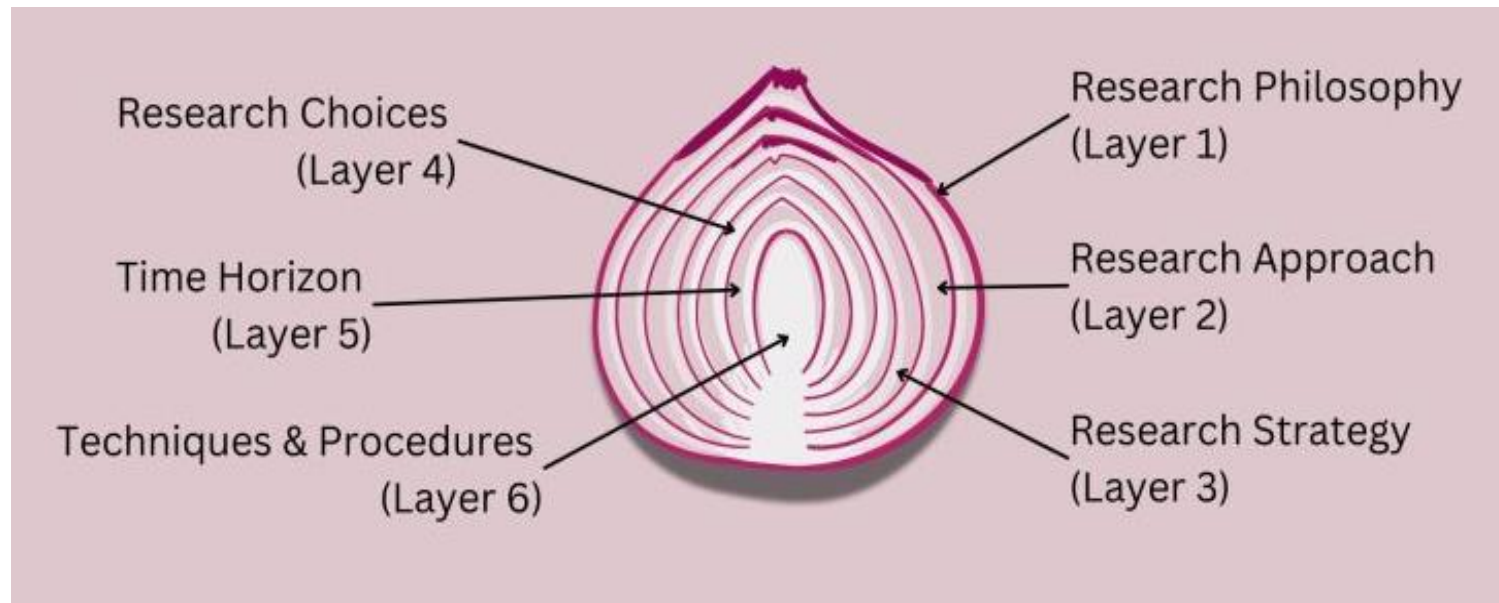
01

The Research Onion & Its Foundations

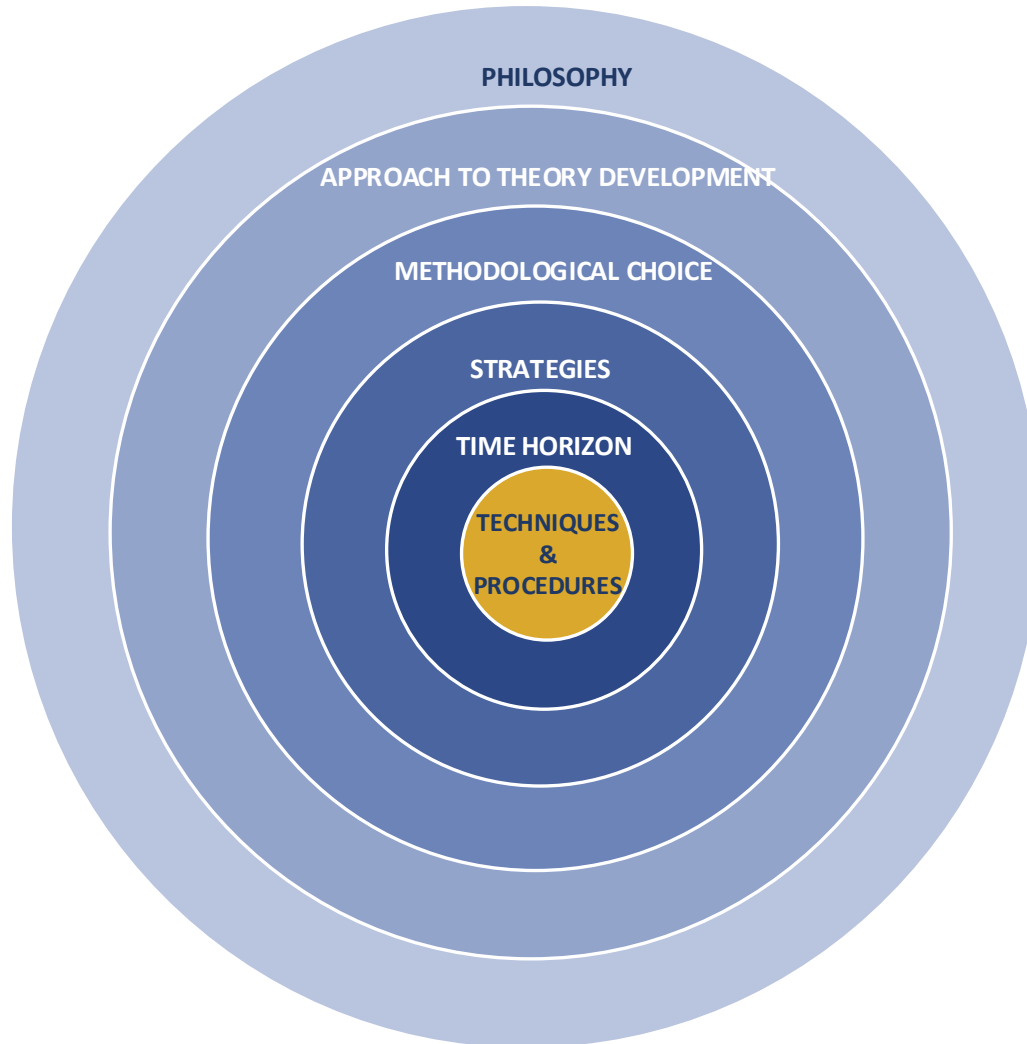
Why philosophy is peeled before you ever choose a method

The Research Onion — Why Philosophy Comes First

- Saunders, Lewis & Thornhill picture the research process as an onion: method, data collection and analysis sit at the centre, but several layers of assumption must be peeled back to get there.
- It is tempting to start a research project by asking 'should I use a questionnaire or interviews?' — but that question belongs deep inside the onion, not at its surface.
- The outer layers are not discarded once you reach the centre — they are taken-for-granted assumptions about how the world works, and making them explicit lets you examine, question and defend them.
- Every research question could, in principle, be studied from more than one philosophical position — the onion is a guide to making a deliberate choice, not a rigid formula.



The Research Onion — Six Layers to Peel Back



- 1 Philosophy**
Positivism, realism, interpretivism, pragmatism
- 2 Approach to Theory Development**
Deductive, inductive, abductive
- 3 Methodological Choice**
Quantitative, qualitative, or mixed methods
- 4 Strategies**
Survey, case study, experiment, action research...
- 5 Time Horizon**
Cross-sectional or longitudinal
- 6 Techniques & Procedures**
Data collection and analysis — the very centre

The Three Pillars of a Research Philosophy

Ontology

The nature of reality

GUIDING QUESTION

What do I believe reality actually is — a fixed external fact, or something socially constructed?

Epistemology

What counts as knowledge

GUIDING QUESTION

What kind of evidence am I willing to accept as credible knowledge in my field?

Axiology

The role of values

GUIDING QUESTION

How far do my own values shape what I study and how I interpret it?

These three — sometimes called the metaphysical assumptions of a research paradigm — combine to form the philosophical position you bring to every study.

Ontology in Practice — Objectivism vs. Subjectivism

Objectivism

- Social entities (e.g. 'the organisation', 'the manager') exist as facts, external to and independent of the people within them
- Structures, roles and systems have a reality of their own, largely unaffected by who currently occupies them
- Associated with the 'resources' researcher — comfortable treating organisational facts like objects: countable, measurable, external

Subjectivism

- Social phenomena are produced by the perceptions and actions of the people involved — they do not exist 'out there' independent of people
- Concepts like 'organisational culture' or 'leadership' are continuously constructed and reconstructed through social interaction
- Associated with the 'feelings' researcher — concerned with meanings, attitudes and lived experience rather than fixed facts

02

Four Research Philosophies

Positivism · Realism · Interpretivism · Pragmatism

Four Philosophies at a Glance

P Positivism

Studies observable social reality the way a natural scientist would, aiming for law-like generalisations

R Realism

Holds that a reality exists independently of the human mind, though our access to it may be direct or filtered

I Interpretivism

Focuses on understanding the subjective meanings people attach to their social world

Pr Pragmatism

Lets the research question — not a fixed allegiance — decide which philosophical position fits best

Positivism — Working in the Tradition of the Natural Scientist

THE DEDUCTIVE LOGIC OF POSITIVISM



Only observable facts count

The natural scientist's stance: measurable phenomena are the only credible data.



Law-like generalisations

Findings should hold across contexts, as physical science seeks universal laws.

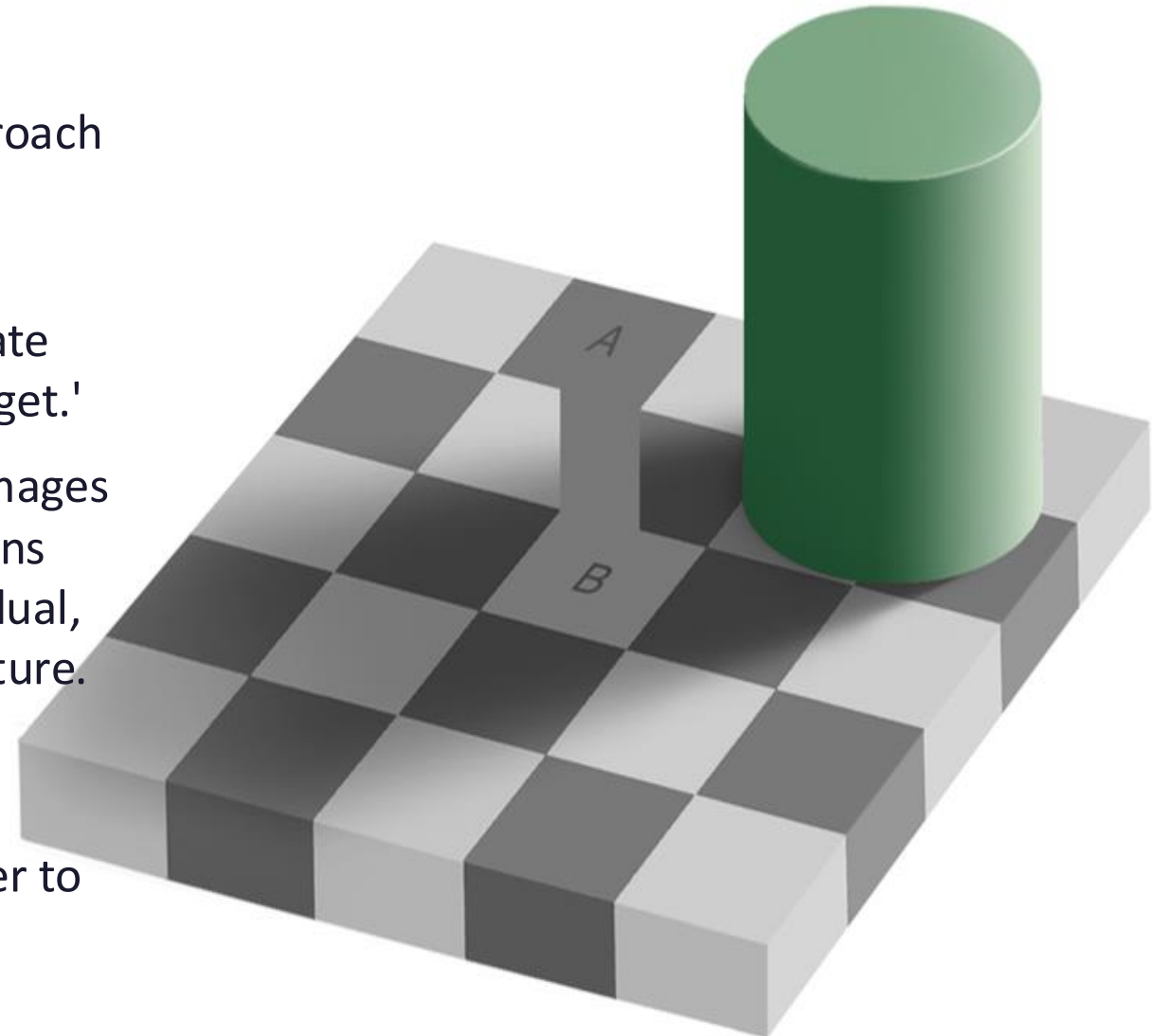


A tendency, not a strict rule

Positivism usually favours structured methods, large samples and quantitative analysis — but positivist logic can also be applied to data gathered qualitatively.

Realism — Does Reality Exist Independently of Our Minds?

- Shares positivism's assumption that a scientific approach can build knowledge, but focuses squarely on the question of what is 'really' out there.
- Direct realism: what our senses show us is an accurate portrayal of the world — 'what you see is what you get.'
- Critical realism: our senses give us sensations and images of reality, not reality directly — and those impressions can mislead us, so multiple levels of analysis (individual, group, organisation) are needed to build a fuller picture.
- The critical realist's view — that the social world is constantly shifting — sits comfortably with business research that aims to explain a phenomenon in order to recommend change.



Interpretivism — Understanding Humans as Social Actors



Complexity over laws

Business and management are too complex to reduce to law-like generalisations without losing what matters.



People as social actors

We each interpret our own role and the roles of others, much like actors interpreting a part.



Two intellectual roots

Phenomenology: how people make sense of the world. Symbolic interactionism: how we adjust to others.



An empathetic stance

Enter the social world of your participants and understand it from their point of view.

Pragmatism — Let the Research Question Decide



Let the research question decide

Debating which philosophy is objectively 'correct' is often beside the point in practice.

PHILOSOPHY AS A CONTINUUM, NOT AN EITHER/OR CHOICE

A study can shift position as the question
requires

More objective

Measurement, hypothesis testing



Useful beats 'correct'

A position that answers your question better is a legitimate basis for choosing it.

More interpretive

Meaning, context, social actors



Mixed methods by design

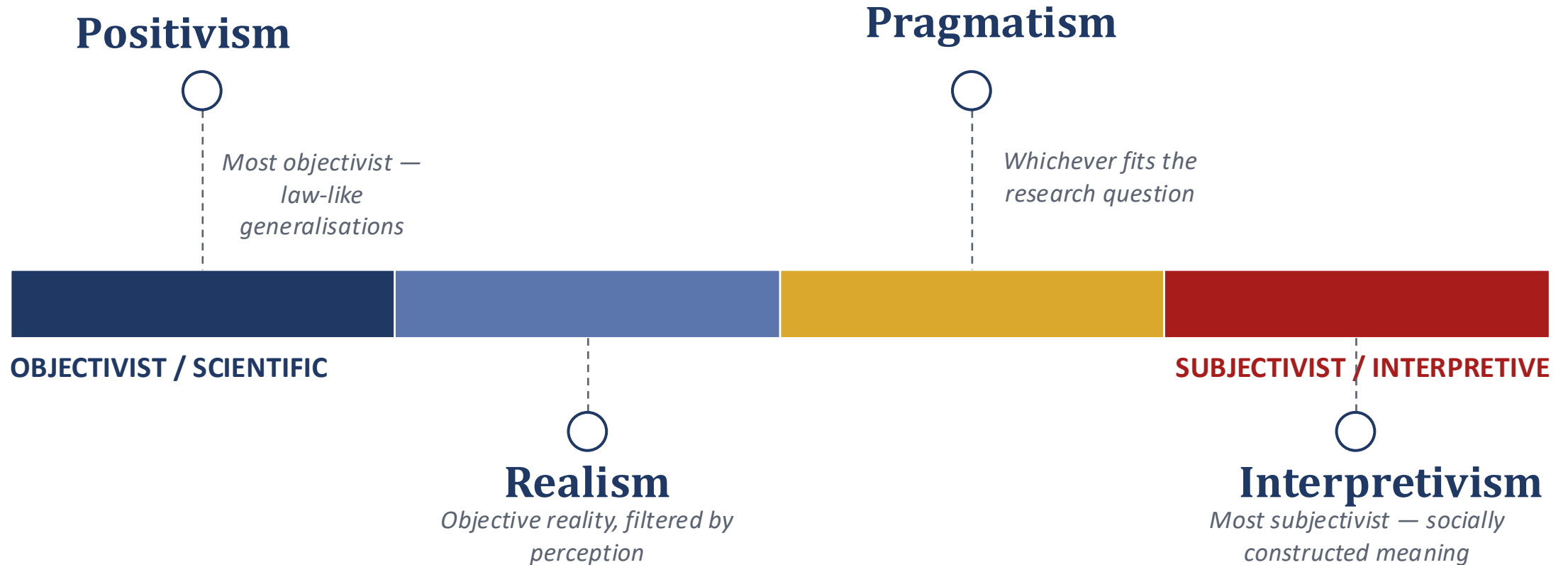
Quantitative and qualitative data can combine within a single study.

Comparing the Four Philosophies

	Positivism	Realism	Interpretivism	Pragmatism
Ontology	Reality is external, objective, and the same for everyone	Reality exists independently of the mind, but our access to it may be direct or filtered	Reality is socially constructed and can differ between people	Whichever view of reality best helps answer the research question
Epistemology	Only observable phenomena count as credible knowledge; seeks causal, law-like patterns	Observable phenomena are credible, but our sensations of them may need correcting for context	Knowledge is found in subjective meanings and the details of specific situations	Both observable facts and subjective meanings can count, depending on what the question needs
Axiology	Research should be value-free; the researcher stays objective and detached	Research is shaped by the researcher's worldview, though a scientific stance is still sought	Research is value-bound; the researcher is part of what is studied and cannot be fully detached	Values shape interpretation; the researcher moves between objective and subjective stances
Typical methods	Structured, often large-sample, quantitative	Method chosen to fit the subject matter — quantitative or qualitative	Small-sample, in-depth, qualitative	Mixed methods — quantitative and qualitative combined

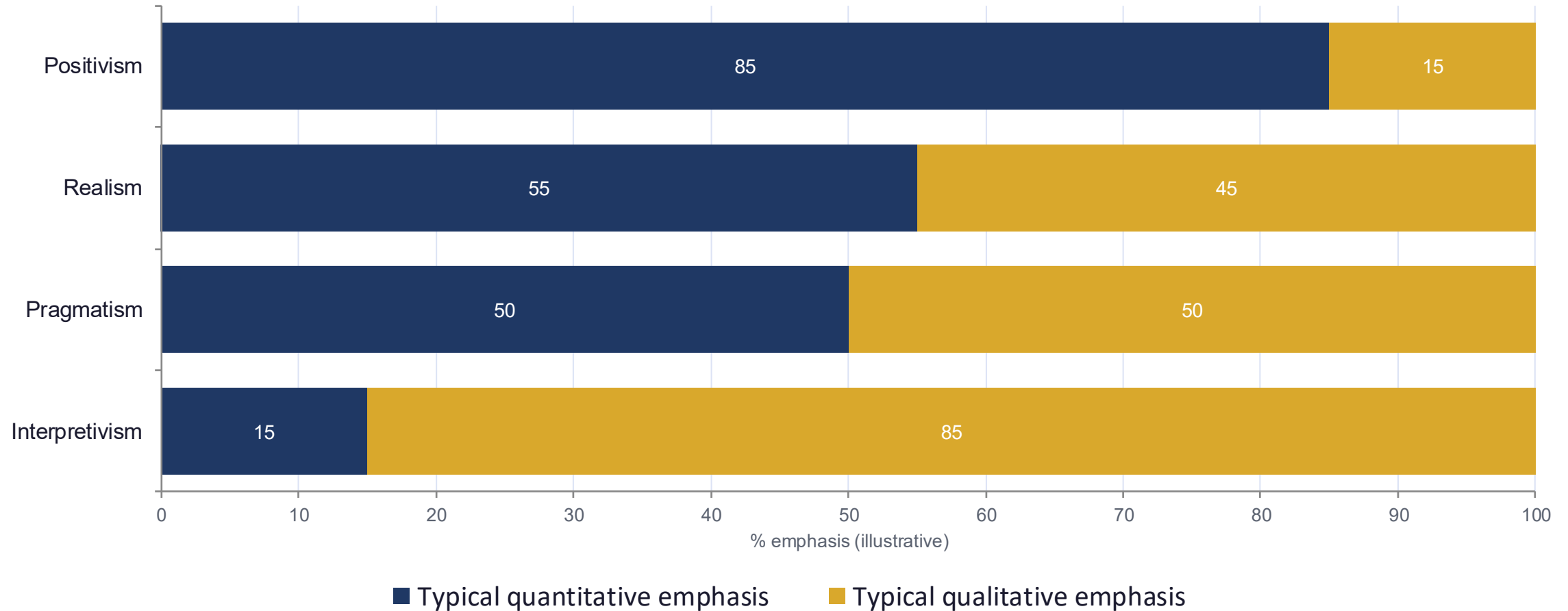
Adapted and paraphrased from Saunders, Lewis & Thornhill's comparison of research philosophies in management research.

Where Each Philosophy Sits on the Objectivist–Subjectivist Spectrum



A visual simplification — in practice, philosophical positions sit on a continuum rather than in fixed boxes.

Typical Quantitative vs. Qualitative Emphasis



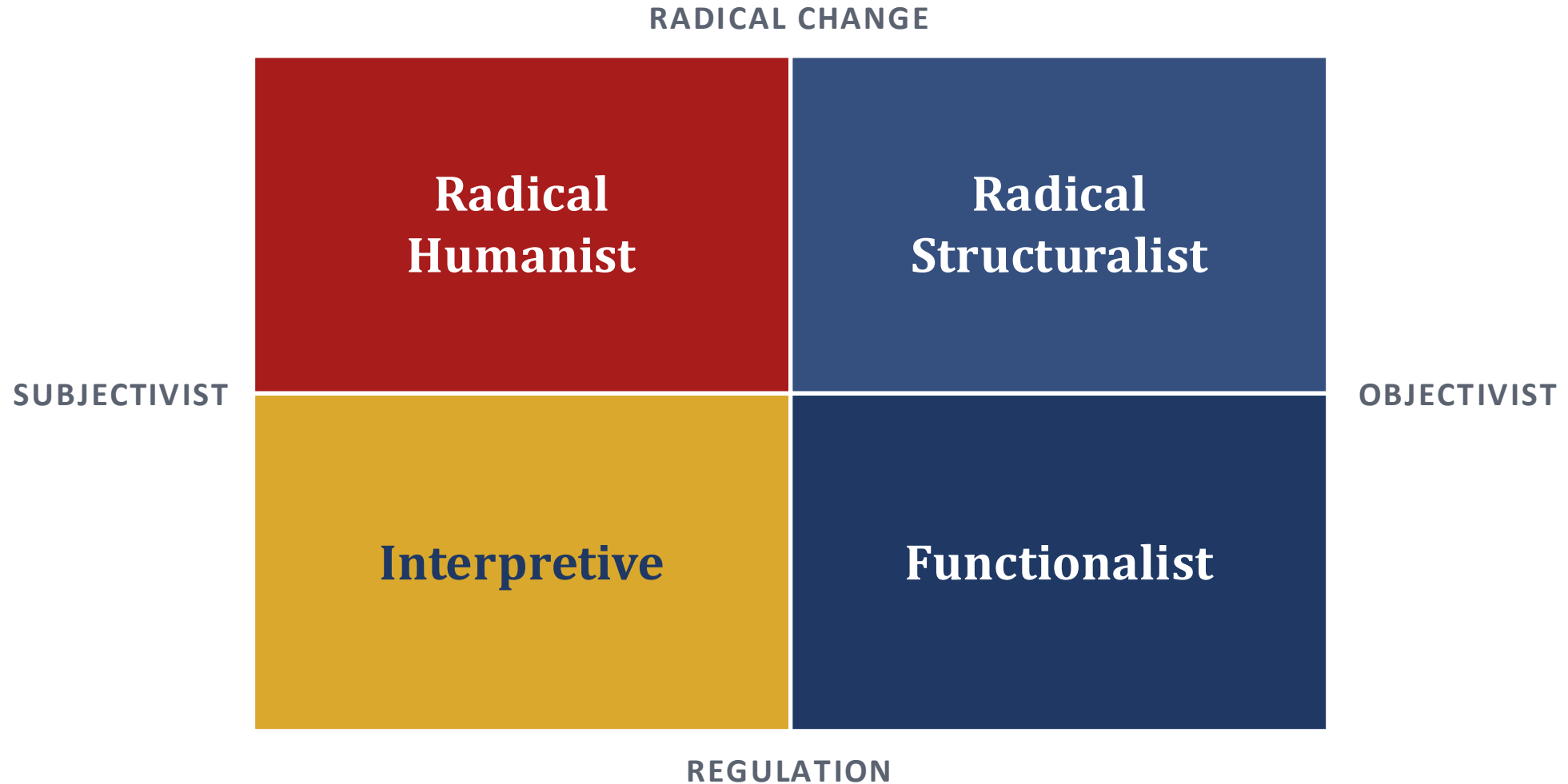
a teaching simplification of typical tendencies, not a measured statistic. The actual balance always depends on the specific research question.

03

The Four Research Paradigms

Burrell & Morgan's map of assumptions about science and society

The Paradigm Quadrant



Most business and management research operates in the functionalist paradigm — objectivist, problem-oriented, working within the current organisational order.

The Four Paradigms Explained

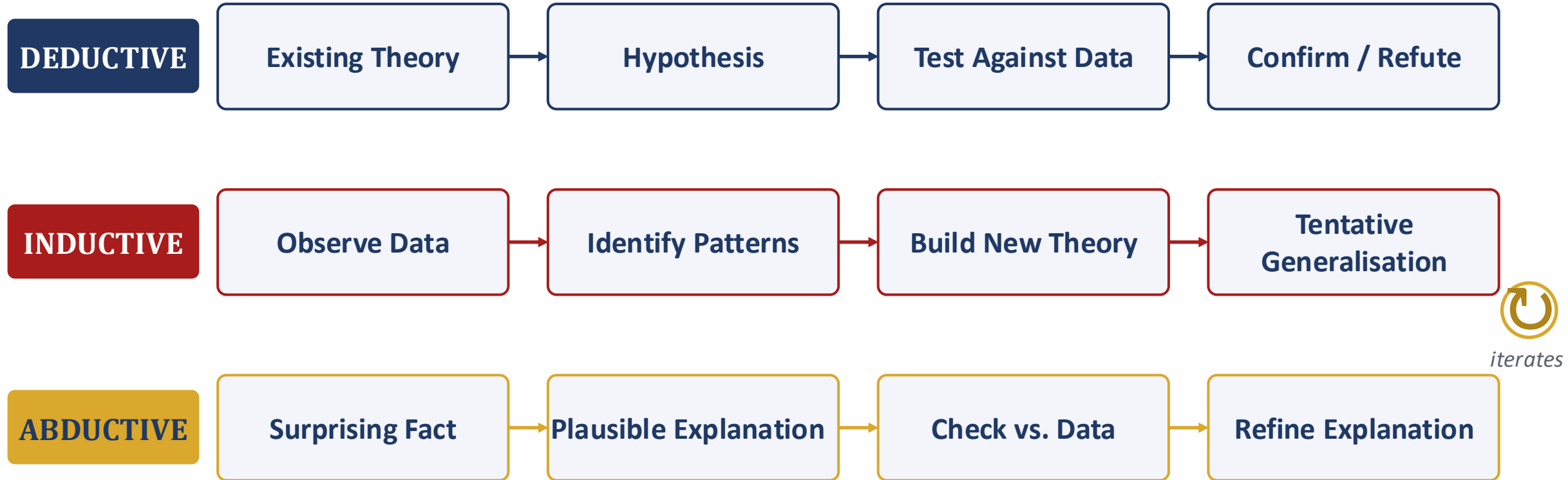
Paradigm	Ontology / Stance	Concerned With
Functionalist	Objectivist + Regulation	Rational explanation of organisational problems; practical, problem-oriented solutions within the existing order — the paradigm most business research sits in
Interpretive	Subjectivist + Regulation	Understanding the meanings organisational members attach to their world, without necessarily seeking to change it
Radical Humanist	Subjectivist + Radical Change	Challenging existing social patterns so people can move beyond constraints on their potential
Radical Structuralist	Objectivist + Radical Change	Fundamental change based on analysing structures such as power relationships and patterns of conflict

04

Research Approaches

Deduction · Induction · Abduction

Three Directions of Reasoning



Deduction moves general → specific. Induction moves specific → general. Abduction cycles between a puzzling observation and the best available explanation.

Deduction vs. Induction — Two Classic Directions

Deductive (theory → data)

- Starts from existing theory; develops a hypothesis (or hypotheses) to test
- Designs a research strategy specifically to test that hypothesis
- Moves from the general (theory) to the specific (observations)
- Best suited when a well-developed theory already exists for your topic
- Typically favours structured, quantitative designs — though not exclusively

Inductive (data → theory)

- Starts by collecting data on a phenomenon of interest
- Builds or refines a theory as a result of analysing that data
- Moves from the specific (observations) to the general (theory)
- Best suited when existing theory is thin, contested, or doesn't fit your context
- Typically favours smaller samples and qualitative, in-depth designs

Abduction — Moving Between Data and Theory

STEP 1

Surprising observation

You notice a fact in your context that existing theory does not fully explain.



STEP 2

Most plausible explanation

Work backwards from the puzzle to the best explanation available.



STEP 3

Test against data

Check the explanation against further evidence, then revise it.

Iterative loop: abduction moves back and forth between data and theory, not in one direction like deduction or induction

WHY IT MATTERS

The most realistic account of how research actually unfolds, and a good fit with mixed methods.

WHEN TO USE IT

When something unexpected in your context is not adequately accounted for by existing theory.

Matching an Approach to Your Type of Study

Approach	Starting Point	Best Suited When...	Example Study
Deductive	Existing theory	A well-established theory already exists and you want to test whether it holds in a new context	Testing whether Technology Acceptance Model predicts mobile banking adoption among Kenyan SMEs
Inductive	Observed data	Little theory exists on your topic, or existing theory doesn't seem to fit your context well	Exploring how informal traders in an unregulated market experience financial risk, to build a grounded explanation
Abductive	A surprising fact or anomaly	Something you observe in practice doesn't match what existing theory predicts, and needs a new or adapted explanation	Investigating why a well-designed strategy is being undermined at implementation level in ways theory doesn't explain

05

Justifying Your Position

The philosophy diagnostic exercise — applied to your own topic

How to Justify a Research Philosophy for Your Topic

- Start from your research question, not the other way round — ask what kind of knowledge you actually need to answer it.
- State your ontological position: do you view the phenomenon in your topic as an objective fact, or as something socially constructed by the people involved?
- State your epistemological position: what would count as credible evidence for your specific question — numbers, narratives, or both?
- Be honest about your axiological position: where do your own values and experience sit in relation to what you are studying, and could that introduce bias you need to manage?
- A good justification names the philosophy, explains why it fits your question and context, and acknowledges what a different philosophy would have offered instead.

The Philosophy Diagnostic Exercise

Applied to your own emerging topic — answer each honestly, there are no wrong answers:

1. Nature of reality: Do I think the core phenomenon in my topic exists as an objective fact, or is it produced by the people experiencing it?
2. Acceptable knowledge: Would I trust a numeric measure of this phenomenon on its own, or do I need people's own accounts to really understand it?
3. Role of values: How much of my own experience or opinion about this topic am I bringing in — and is that a strength or a risk for this study?
4. Relationship to the research: Am I standing outside what I'm studying looking in, or am I in some way part of it?

In pairs: *discuss your answers, then together name the philosophy (or blend) that best fits — and be ready to defend it.*

This Week's Practical Deliverables

- Complete the philosophy diagnostic exercise for your own emerging topic
- Write a short paragraph (150–200 words) stating and justifying your research philosophy
- Identify whether your study is best approached deductively, inductively, or abductively — and why
- Bring both to next week's session on Research Design for discussion

